

Finding Problems & Opportunities

EMPOWER 40K · GGFG

Module 2

Empower Lab — EMPOWER 40K

Finding Problems & Opportunities

An educational module on noticing real challenges, understanding unmet needs, and spotting gaps where you can create value.

Introduction

In Module 1, you learned that entrepreneurship begins with how you see—paying attention to what is happening around you.

In this module, you will practice looking closer: noticing problems in everyday life, asking better questions, and learning what those problems reveal about people's needs.

Some challenges are obvious. Others are so common that people accept them without thinking: “That is just how things are.” Entrepreneurs pause and ask a different question: “Does it have to be this way?”

Problems can be frustrating, but they are also useful information. When people struggle, wait, waste time, or spend more than they should, it often signals a need that is not being fully met.

You will not try to solve everything at once. Instead, you will learn how to investigate one problem deeply enough to decide whether it is worth exploring as a real opportunity.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this module, you should be able to:

1. Identify problems that people experience in your community.
 2. Use observation and questions to understand a problem more deeply.
 3. Identify the needs behind the problems people experience.
 4. Explain how problems can reveal potential opportunities.
 5. Recognize gaps in existing solutions.
 6. Determine whether a problem is worth exploring further.
 7. Identify at least one opportunity you would like to investigate.
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Start with the Problem

Many people begin entrepreneurship by asking:

“What business should I start?”

But that may not be the best place to begin.

A better question is:

“What problem can I help solve?”

Businesses create value by helping people solve problems, meet needs, or achieve something they want.

Imagine that students in your community have to travel a long distance every time they need to print an assignment.

You might simply notice:

“Students have to travel far to print.”

But an entrepreneur becomes curious.

Why do they have to travel so far?

Are there no printing services nearby?

Are the existing services too expensive?

Are they open at the wrong times?

Do students need other services too?

The more you understand the problem, the more clearly you can see where an opportunity might exist.

Start with the problem.

Do not begin by asking:

“What should I sell?”

Begin by asking:

“What problem can I help solve?”

Quick prompt: What problem do you notice again and again—and who does it affect most?

Observe Your Community

You do not need to look far to find problems.

Start where you are.

Look at your school.

Look at your neighborhood.

Look at the market.

Look at transportation.

Look at small businesses.

Look at farms.

Look at how people communicate, shop, work, study, and move around.

Pay attention to what people complain about.

Notice what takes too long.

Notice what costs too much.

Notice what is difficult to access.

Notice what is unreliable.

Notice what people have simply learned to live with.

These observations can reveal problems worth exploring.

Try This

Spend some time today observing your surroundings.

Write down **five problems** you notice.

Do not try to solve them yet.

Do not decide whether they are good or bad business ideas.

Just observe.

You are learning to see what others may overlook.

What I observed	Where I observed it
[Problem 1]	[Where you noticed it]
[Problem 2]	[Where you noticed it]
[Problem 3]	[Where you noticed it]
[Problem 4]	[Where you noticed it]
[Problem 5]	[Where you noticed it]

Look Beyond the Obvious Problem

Sometimes the problem you first notice is not the real problem.

Imagine farmers in a community are losing vegetables before they reach customers.

The obvious problem is:

“The vegetables are spoiling.”

But why?

Maybe transportation takes too long.

Maybe farmers do not have proper storage.

Maybe they cannot find buyers quickly.

Maybe packaging is damaging the vegetables.

Maybe farmers are producing more than the market can absorb.

The first problem you see may only be the surface.

Entrepreneurs learn to go deeper.

Ask:

Why is this happening?

Then ask again:

Why?

Keep asking until you understand the situation better.

You are not trying to make the problem complicated.

You are trying to understand what is really causing it.

Dig deeper:

What might be causing this problem?

What makes it worse?

What have people already tried?

What is still not working?

Understand the People

A problem is not just something that looks wrong from the outside.

You need to understand the people experiencing it.

You may think you have found a major problem, but the people affected may see it differently.

Or you may think something is a small inconvenience when it is actually costing people significant amounts of time or money.

This is why entrepreneurs listen.

Talk to people.

Ask about their experiences.

Ask how they currently deal with the problem.

Ask what makes the situation difficult.

Ask what they wish could be different.

For example, instead of asking:

“Would you use my new delivery service?”

Ask:

“How do you currently get things delivered?”

Then ask:

“What is difficult about the process?”

And:

“What do you normally do when that happens?”

You are not trying to convince them to buy something.

You are trying to understand.

Remember:

Do not assume. Investigate.

Who is affected?	What do they feel / need?
[Group: e.g., students, vendors, farmers]	[What they struggle with + what would help]
[Group 2]	[Feelings / needs 2]

What Is an Unmet Need?

Sometimes people have a problem because something they need is missing or is not being provided well enough.

This is called an **unmet need**.

For example, imagine young people in a community want to learn practical digital skills.

Training may exist.

But perhaps it is too expensive.

Or it is too far away.

Or it is only offered during times when young people are working.

The need exists.

A solution exists.

But the need is not fully met.

That gap may reveal an opportunity.

An unmet need does not automatically mean you have found a business.

But it gives you something worth investigating.

Ask:

What do people need?

What are they receiving now?

What is missing?

In simple words: An unmet need is something people *want or require*, but they can't get it easily, affordably, safely, or consistently—yet.

Turning Problems into Opportunities

A problem becomes an opportunity when there is a meaningful way to create value by addressing it.

Think about a simple example.

The Problem

Small farmers struggle to reach customers directly.

The Need

Farmers need reliable access to buyers.

The Gap

Current ways of connecting farmers and customers are difficult or unreliable.

The Opportunity

There may be an opportunity to create a better way for farmers and customers to connect.

Notice that we did not immediately jump to a solution.

We first tried to understand the problem.

That is important.

Entrepreneurs can become too excited about their ideas and forget to ask whether people actually need them.

Good entrepreneurship begins with understanding.

Problem	Unmet need	Possible opportunity
[Problem you observed]	[What people are missing]	[A practical idea to help]
[Problem 2]	[Need 2]	[Opportunity 2]

Not Every Problem Is an Opportunity

You will find many problems.

That is normal.

But you cannot solve all of them.

And not every problem is a strong opportunity.

Before spending your time and resources on an idea, ask:

- **Is this a real problem?**
- **Who experiences it?**
- **How often does it happen?**
- **How important is it?**
- **How are people solving it now?**
- **What is missing from the current solution?**
- **Could I realistically create value here?**

These questions do not give you a perfect answer.

They help you decide whether a problem is worth exploring further.

Reality check: A good opportunity solves a real problem for real people in a way that can actually be delivered (time, cost, skills, trust, and safety matter).

Your Opportunity Map

Go back to the five problems you identified earlier.

Choose the **three that interest you most**.

For each one, answer the prompts below. You do not need to have a business idea yet—you are still investigating.

Map Element	Your notes
Problem	[What is happening?]
People	[Who experiences this problem?]
Need	[What do these people need?]
Current solution	[How are they dealing with the problem now?]
Gap	[What seems to be missing?]
Possible opportunity	[Where might you be able to create value?]

Empower Lab Challenge

Listen Before You Build

Choose one problem from your opportunity map.

Find **three people** who experience that problem.

Talk to them.

Do not pitch your business idea.

Do not tell them what you think they need.

Listen.

Ask:

“Can you tell me about your experience with this problem?”

Then ask:

“How do you currently deal with it?”

And finally:

“What would make this easier or better for you?”

Write down what you learn.

You may discover that the problem is bigger than you thought.

You may discover that it is smaller.

You may discover that people already have a solution.

Or you may discover an opportunity you had not noticed before.

All of those are useful discoveries.

Complete today:

- ☐ Choose 1 problem from your opportunity map.
- ☐ Talk to 3 people who experience it.
- ☐ Write what you learned (what is hard, what they do now, what would help).

Write 1 sentence about what seems true so far (without jumping to a solution).

Reflection

Take a moment to think about what you discovered.

Write your answers:

- What problem surprised you the most?
- What did you learn from talking to people?
- What is one opportunity you would like to explore further?
- What question do you still need to answer?

A Thought to Carry With You

The world is full of problems.

Entrepreneurs do not try to solve all of them.

They learn to find the problems they can understand, the people they can serve, and the places where they can create real value.

Do not rush to build. **First, learn to see.**

Then learn to understand.

Then recognize the opportunity.

The solution comes next.